

HPS Big 3 + Little C Day Hike

Santa Cruz (HPS), San Rafael (HPS), McKinley (HPS), and Cachuma Mountain (LPS)

33.3 miles, 9000 ft of gain

April 17th, 2010

After last week's rather brutal 35 mile slog through the Santa Ana Mountains we had one more very long training hike planned before I disappeared into the Sierra for a week and then we all get ready for Big 4.

John had been forced to drop out due to knee pain which is something I can sadly relate to which left three of us training for Big 4 BKE. Also along for this jaunt was Diane Perke of San Diego WBC fame along though she stated from the beginning she wasn't a peak bagger and as such didn't intend to do all the peaks.

The plan was to meet at the trailhead way out in the mountains of Venture County at 6:15 am which for me in Orange County was a 3+ hour drive. Originally I planned to drive out the sleep at the trailhead but thanks to the ever so wonderful San Francisco Airport I ended up missing a connecting flight and not even making it home to my apartment until almost 9 pm. Ah well, plan B, 2 am wakeup!

The drive was long but music and coffee do wonders especially when I'm headed out to hike.



The San Diego crew all came out midday Friday and spent the night in a Motel 6 down the hill and I beat them to the trailhead by about 15 minutes. The peak guide for this hike talks about an abandoned ranger station but I sure didn't see anything.



The others arrived and we set off bundled up against the cold wind.



The road climbed gradually but was in good condition so things went quickly.



3 miles from the trailhead we came to the first peak of the day, Cachuma Mountain. This peak wasn't even a part of the standard Big 3 hike due to being on the all but ignored Lower Peak Section as opposed

to the Hundred Peak Section. However, both Christine and I seem to have religious issues around walking past peaks so up we went.



No summit register but we did find a benchmark. And it was damn cold due to the hard wind.





After a very brief pause at the top we descended the far side back to the road and continued another 6 miles until we reached McKinley Saddle and the site used as a campsite when these peaks were done as a rather kinder two day excursion.

We reached the saddle feeling good, those of us who had done the Santa Ana Mountain ridge the previous weekend commenting on how much softer and kinder this trail was.

I had decided to get the furthest peak out of the way first just in case it got last and our peak bagging willpower started to falter (Never!) We had an 8 mile out and back from McKinley Saddle to hit Santa Cruz and get back and all but the last part was on trail. No problem.



Granted that trail dropped. A lot. Diane came along for the first three miles but then turned back to go take a nap on the saddle and the three of us continued towards our goal.



There is a bump you have to pass right before Santa Cruz itself. A trail passes around the lefthand side but when we followed this in the hopes of skirting around the bump we found it was blocked completely by a rather large fallen tree.



So we backtracked and went up a firebreak we had passed a few hundred feet back. From the top of the bump we could see the saddle between our bump and Santa Cruz and also a rather clear trail we needed to meet up with. We couldn't see anything heading down however so after poking around a bit we set down what I thought was a quasi use trail down the left-hand side.

Bad idea.



It wasn't too bad at first but the brush became thicker and it was mixed with the burned remains of trees from the fire several years ago. Also there were loose rocks which made footing somewhat treacherous.

Even better when we did make the saddle we looked back and saw there was a continuation of the firebreak along the other side of the bump. We looked going back and it was in a rather non-obvious spot.

We crossed to Santa Cruz itself and took the use trail that started almost from the saddle. It started out with a clean cut path through trees that had obviously been maintained at some effort but that soon let us out in the burn area again.



While the route was well ducked (a bit too much actually) the going was a bit slow due to the same combination of brush, loose rock, and sharp burned branches sticking up in all directions.



We made the summit which was covered in bugs and extremely non-memorable. We stayed just long enough to sign in on the register and headed down.



At one point there was a trail or firebreak heading up in the general direction of San Rafael. We didn't take it due to having to meet Diane up at the saddle and also the worry we'd end up in a nasty bushwhack but it's worth looking into next time I do this route.

The climb back to McKinley Saddle seemed long though I was making enough of a dent in my 7 liters of water that my pack was a bit lighter.



We found Diane stretched out on the saddle and she decided she'd wait for us there rather than tag along for the 3 miles round trip to San Rafael.



San Rafael involves going about a mile and a half on trail then climbing about 50 ft of trail to reach the summit. Easy stuff. We were all hoping to make up for time lost on Santa Cruz. But...



Turns out the traces of snow we had seen while approaching McKinley Saddle were a bit more than traces.

It covered the trail in half a dozen sections enough where we had to slow down and kick steps to traverse across. In one case it was hairy enough I took us up the ridge about 50 feet to get around a particularly icy section with a bad drop below. So much for making up time.

The peak itself was also a bit unremarkable, just one more bump along a ridge full of them. It did however give us a nice view back towards Santa Cruz.

We backtracked to McKinley Saddle, woke Diane from her nap, and set off the half mile to the easiest of the Big 3, McKinley.

Since we finally had all four of us together on a peak it was summit photo time. As I have way to many of people standing side by side with goofy grins on their faces I forced everyone to pose. So...



We returned to the saddle and set off the 9 miles back to the car.

We stopped at McKinley Spring which is where folks generally seem to camp when doing this as a 2+ day backpack.



I had been warned by the HPS guide not to drink the water out of the horse trough not that I would have anyway but the dead squirrel sitting at the bottom of it was the final capper.



We topped of a few extra liters from the corpse free part of the spring, strapped on our headlamps since it was obvious we'd be out after dark, and headed on down the trail.



Our pace started out steady and increased to brisk as it got dark and we all really started to feel the miles.

At long last we popped out at the cars around 10:20 pm which meant we'd been hiking for around 16 hours. Total stats according to my trusty GPS were 33.3 miles, 9000 ft of gain.

We all agreed the route was easier than the Santa Ana Mountains last weekend just due to the softer nature of the trails vs that damn Main Divide truck trail. I had managed to pick up a rather ugly blister after my boots became soaked leading through the snow on San Rafael but other than that and the general feeling my feet had been reduced to hamburger I didn't feel too bad.



The San Diego crowd was all eager to get on the road for the looong drive home but I wasn't feeling up to driving until 2 am considering the small amount of sleep the night before so I drove my truck back up to the gate, pulled out my trusty bivy, and went to sleep.

The next morning I awoke at 6:30 am and drove home.

And that's basically it for the Big 4 BKE training. While we do have one more weekend between this trip and that one I'll be spending it up in the Sierra at Alabama Hills with SCMA for the Rock Climbing Safety Course graduation bash.